

STRATEGY GUIDE

AI Strategy, Integration & Governance

A comprehensive guide to how we help companies adopt AI that's powerful, accountable, and designed to last. From risk assessment to policy development to hands-on execution.

PREPARED BY
VERA Consulting

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THE AI LANDSCAPE

The adoption is here. The infrastructure isn't.

Adoption has outpaced readiness

88% of organizations now use AI regularly in at least one business function. 92% of Fortune 500 companies have deployed generative AI across their operations. But only 25% have governance frameworks robust enough to match that pace.

88%

of organizations use AI regularly in at least one business function

McKinsey, 2026

The governance gap is real

AI adoption has outrun AI governance by 58 percentage points — the widest enterprise adoption-to-governance gap on record. 78% of executives say they lack confidence their company could pass an independent AI governance audit within 90 days.

92%

of Fortune 500 companies have deployed generative AI

Fortune, 2026

Regulation is accelerating

The EU AI Act is in effect. U.S. states are passing AI-specific legislation. The SEC has issued disclosure guidance. NIST has published its AI Risk Management Framework. FTC enforcement actions are increasing. Companies that built without governance are retrofitting under pressure.

25%

have governance frameworks robust enough to match adoption pace

Grant Thornton, 2026

The gap is widening

McKinsey identifies a small group of "AI high performers" (roughly 6% of companies) that attribute more than 5% of EBIT to AI. These organizations are 2.8x more likely to have fundamentally redesigned their workflows around AI, not just layered it on top.

78%

of executives lack confidence they could pass an AI governance audit

Grant Thornton, 2026

What this means for you

The question isn't whether to adopt AI. That decision has already been made. The question is whether your organization is structured to use it well, govern it properly, and adapt as everything changes. That's what VERA helps with.

\$2.5T

global AI spending in 2026, up 44% year-over-year

Gartner, 2026

Where the impact hits hardest

Financial services, healthcare, legal, insurance, HR, manufacturing, and customer experience are seeing the fastest AI-driven transformation. Companies in regulated industries face the most pressure to get governance right before scaling. The organizations that move first on governance will set the standard for their industries.

The high performer gap

Only 25% of organizations have moved at least 40% of their AI experiments into production. What separates the leaders: they redesigned workflows around AI rather than layering it onto existing processes. They invested in governance early, not after problems emerged. The gap between leaders and everyone else is accelerating.

KEY RISKS

Where AI adoption goes wrong.

Most AI failures aren't technical. They're organizational. These are the six areas where we see companies get caught off guard.

58pt

gap between AI adoption
and governance readiness

01 Bias & Fairness

AI systems inherit and amplify biases from training data. In hiring, lending, healthcare, and insurance, this leads to discriminatory outcomes that create legal exposure and erode public trust.

04 Regulatory Exposure

What's compliant today may not be compliant next quarter. The EU AI Act, state-level legislation, and FTC enforcement are accelerating. Retroactive compliance costs significantly more than building it in from the start.

02 Hallucination & Accuracy

Large language models produce confident outputs that can be factually wrong. Without validation pipelines, incorrect information enters your workflows and corrupts downstream decision-making.

05 Workforce Disruption

Without a transition plan, AI adoption creates friction and talent gaps instead of productivity gains. Organizations that invest in change management see 3x higher adoption rates.

03 Data Privacy & Security

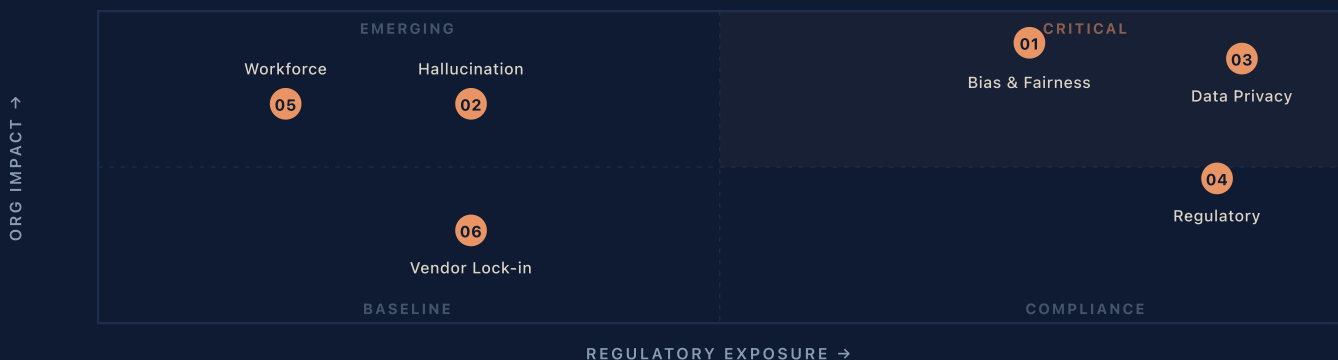
AI creates new attack surfaces — from prompt injection to training data extraction — that traditional security frameworks weren't designed to address. Compliance with GDPR, CCPA, and HIPAA requires AI-specific controls.

06 Vendor Lock-in

Architecture decisions made today determine your flexibility for years. Committing to a single vendor without proper evaluation is expensive to undo and often requires rebuilding from scratch.

RISK LANDSCAPE

How the six risks compare on exposure and impact



"The companies that get AI right aren't the ones that move fastest. They're the ones that build the governance to sustain it."

How we address these risks

We identify which risks are most relevant to your organization and build the governance, policies, and evaluation systems to manage them. Every assessment includes specific mitigation recommendations tied to your operations.

Regulatory frameworks we track

EU AI Act, NIST AI Risk Management Framework, state-level AI legislation (CO, IL, TX, CA), SEC AI disclosure guidance, FTC enforcement precedent, HIPAA AI provisions, SOC 2 AI controls, ISO/IEC 42001. Monitored continuously.

SERVICES

What we offer.

01 AI Strategy

We assess what's feasible, map it to your infrastructure, and build the plan. Not a generic roadmap — a strategy built around your business, your constraints, and where AI is heading in 12, 24, and 36 months.

INCLUDES

Feasibility assessment, architecture planning, vendor evaluation, evaluation criteria, implementation timeline, resource planning

02 AI Integration

AI woven into your workflows at a foundational level — not bolted on as a feature. We handle technical implementation, data pipelines, and change management so your team actually adopts it.

INCLUDES

Workflow design, system integration, data pipeline architecture, performance monitoring, change management, team onboarding

03 AI Governance

Policies, evaluation frameworks, and operational processes designed for where regulation is heading — not just where it is today. Compliant now, adaptable as the landscape shifts.

INCLUDES

Acceptable use policies, data handling protocols, model evaluation criteria, bias testing procedures, incident response, vendor assessment, compliance mapping

04 Training & Enablement

Hands-on training tailored to your industry, your tools, and the specific roles in your organization. From C-suite briefings to technical workshops on prompt engineering and tool evaluation.

INCLUDES

Executive AI briefings, team workshops, AI literacy programs, best practices documentation, ongoing enablement support

05 Policy Development

Standalone policy engagements — practical, enforceable, and aligned with current and emerging regulation. Policies your team can actually follow, not shelf documents that collect dust.

INCLUDES

Acceptable use policy, data governance policy, model evaluation standards, human oversight requirements, vendor management protocols

Research-grounded recommendations · No handoffs to junior teams · Full documentation & knowledge transfer · 30-day post-engagement support

Our approach

Every recommendation traces back to published research, tested benchmarks, or proven production patterns. If something isn't a fit, we'll tell you before you spend a dollar on it.

Every engagement includes

Dedicated point of contact with direct access to senior consultants. Full documentation, complete knowledge transfer, and post-engagement support. We take a small number of engagements so each gets the attention it deserves.

PROCESS

How an engagement works.

Every engagement follows a structured, transparent process. You'll know what we're doing, why, and what you'll have at the end.

TYPICAL TIMELINE

Assessment — 2-3 weeks

Scope of Work — 1 week

Execution — 4-12 weeks

1 Assessment

We start by understanding where you are — infrastructure, AI maturity, goals, and constraints. We evaluate what's working, what's not, and where AI can create real value. The strategy we build is only as good as our understanding of your reality.

Infrastructure review Stakeholder interviews Data readiness Risk identification Competitive landscape

2 Scope of Work

We define exactly what we'll deliver, when, and what success looks like. Every scope of work includes measurable success criteria. We typically present two or three options at different levels of depth so you can choose the engagement that fits your budget and timeline.

Defined deliverables Timeline and milestones Resource requirements Success criteria Investment summary

3 Execution

We do the work — strategy, integration, governance, training, whatever the scope calls for. Regular updates, full documentation, no lock-in. When we're done, you own everything we built. Every engagement includes a 30-day post-completion support window.

Weekly check-ins Progress reporting Full documentation Knowledge transfer Post-engagement support

OUR VISION

"I started VERA because AI is going to change the workforce at an unprecedented pace, and many companies are not prepared for it. We believe in using AI to strengthen human capabilities and being transparent about both the risks and the opportunities ahead."

Brett Ponters, Founder

WHAT TO EXPECT

Direct access to senior consultants. No handoffs to junior teams. Transparent pricing with no hidden fees. Weekly progress reports. Everything we build, you own.

VERA is incorporated as a Public Benefit Corporation. A fixed percentage of every dollar we earn goes to independent AI safety research.

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